A FREE WORKSHEET FROM HOLDING THE LINE

THE SOFTENING CHECK

Catch what you remove before you say it.

Think of one conversation you know needs to happen and have been putting off. A real person and a real topic. Keep it in mind as you fill out the next two pages. Where the worksheet mentions Chapter 1, just use the conversation you have in mind.

You will write two sentences: the one that actually needs to be said, and the one you would probably say if you walked into the room today. The gap between them shows you what you have been removing to keep the moment comfortable.

> *Direct statements become suggestions. Clear expectations get softened into reminders.*

Holding the Line: A Leader's Guide to Toxic Empathy walks through the whole pattern in seven short chapters, each with a worksheet like this one. archetypeoriginal.com/guides/holding-the-line

Use a pen. Be honest. Nobody else has to see it.

THE SOFTENING CHECK

Go back to the conversation you picked in Chapter 1. Write the sentence that actually needs to be said, as plainly as you can. Then write the sentence you would probably say if you walked into the room today. Compare them and see what got removed.

The sentence that needs to be said. Name the behavior, the standard, and what has to change. No cushioning.

The sentence I would probably say. Be honest. Write it the way it would really come out of your mouth.

What got removed? Check every one that applies.

What got removed	Check
The specific behavior (I described it vaguely)	☐
The specific examples (dates, work, moments)	☐
The expectation (I hinted instead of stating it)	☐
The timeline (no "by when")	☐
What happens if it does not change	☐
A direct statement turned into a question or suggestion	☐
Other:	☐

THE SOFTENING CHECK

The words I used to soften it. Circle or list the cushioning words in your second sentence ("just," "maybe," "if possible," "kind of," "when you get a chance," "a little").

Which reason am I using to delay? Write the one that sounds most responsible to you.

What am I afraid will happen in the room if I say the first sentence instead of the second?

Rewrite. Keep the respect. Put back what you removed.